BONUS 2 OF 5

The First Bag Fast-Track

A finished bag, ready to sell, the same day you open the book



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> *A short, no-fluff guide so that the same day you open the book, you already have a finished bag ready to sell.*

Welcome: One Bag, One Afternoon

You bought a big book of patterns. That is wonderful, but a big book can feel like a big mountain. This little guide is the shortcut. We will pick one small bag, gather a few cheap supplies, and finish it in about five hours.

Why one bag first? Because a finished bag in your hands teaches you more than ten pages of reading. You will learn the counting rhythm, you will see how the pieces come together, and you will have something real to show a friend or to photograph and sell.

There is no sewing machine here and no measuring tape. You only count holes. If you can count to four, you can make this bag.

> **What you will make**
>
> A 'Mini' clutch bag with horizontal stripes in two colors. Each stripe is 4 holes tall. It is Pattern #001 from Chapter 1 (Everyday Classics) of the book. The finished clutch is about 6 inches wide, 4 inches tall and 1.5 inches deep.

Your Shopping List (About $5 to $10)

Everything below is easy to find at a craft store, a big discount store, or online. Prices vary by store, brand and where you live, so treat the numbers as a rough guide. If you already own yarn or felt, your cost drops even lower.

ITEM	HOW MUCH YOU NEED	AROUND WHAT IT COSTS
Plastic canvas, 7-count (7 holes per inch)	2 sheets, standard size (about 10.5 × 13.5 in)	$0.50 to $1.50 per sheet
Worsted-weight acrylic yarn (4-ply), Color A	1 small skein or about 40 yards	$1 to $2.50
Worsted-weight acrylic yarn (4-ply), Color B	1 small skein or about 40 yards	$1 to $2.50
Blunt tapestry needle, size 16 or 18	1 needle	$1 to $2.50 (often sold in a pack)
Felt for the lining	2 sheets, 9 × 12 in	$0.30 to $1 per sheet

ITEM	HOW MUCH YOU NEED	AROUND WHAT IT COSTS
Chain strap or a few feet of chain with 2 jump rings	About 20 to 24 inches	$1.50 to $4
Hot glue sticks (if you have no glue gun, a craft glue works too)	2 or 3 sticks	$0.50 to $1
Optional: magnetic snap for the flap	1 snap	$1 to $2

Total estimate: roughly $5 to $10, depending on what you already have at home and what you choose for the chain. Prices vary, so do not worry if your cart comes out a little higher or lower.

> **Money-saving tips**
>
> Use leftover yarn from any old project. Cut the chain from an old purse or a thrift-store belt chain. Buy felt by the single sheet, not by the pack. A cheap sewing-section scissors is fine, but keep it only for craft work.

Choosing your two colors

Pick one dark color and one light color so the stripes stand out clearly. Navy and cream, black and white, or burgundy and soft pink all look rich. Avoid two colors that are almost the same; the stripes will disappear.

Your Hour-by-Hour Plan

Here is a realistic schedule for a beginner. If you stitch faster, you will finish sooner. If you stop for tea, that is fine too.

HOUR	WHAT YOU DO	RESULT AT THE END OF THE HOUR
Hour 0 (15 to 30 min)	Gather supplies, read the safety notes, count and cut the 6 canvas panels	Six clean canvas pieces ready to stitch
Hour 1	Stitch the front panel (42 × 30 holes) with the stripe pattern	Front panel done
Hour 2	Stitch the back panel (same as the front)	Front and back done

HOUR	WHAT YOU DO	RESULT AT THE END OF THE HOUR
Hour 3	Stitch the 2 side panels and the base panel; stitch the flap if you want one	All pieces stitched
Hour 4	Join the panels with whipstitch and finish the edges	Your bag has its shape
Hour 5	Attach the chain, glue in the felt lining, final check	A finished bag, ready for photos

> **Do not rush Hour 0**
> Counting and cutting carefully at the start saves you from fixing mistakes later. Plastic canvas is easy to trim but impossible to add back.

Safety First

This is a gentle craft, but you will use two tools that can hurt if you hurry. Read this short section before you begin.

- **Scissors:** cut away from your body and your fingers. Keep your free hand flat on the canvas, a few inches from the blade. Plastic canvas can leave sharp little points; trim them right away.
- **Hot glue gun:** the tip and the glue are very hot. Always place the gun on a heat-safe surface or its stand. Never touch fresh glue with your bare finger. Keep it away from children and pets, and unplug it when you are done.
- **Small parts:** jump rings, snaps and needles must be kept away from small children and pets.
- **Your eyes and your back:** work in good light and take a short stretch break each hour.

The Pattern at a Glance: Stripes #001

The design is very simple: horizontal stripes that alternate between two colors. Every stripe is 4 holes tall. The front and back panels are 42 holes wide and 30 holes tall.

Thirty holes do not divide evenly by four, so here is the exact order, from the top of the panel down. It uses a small 2-hole starter band so the stripes finish neatly at the bottom.

ROWS (TOP TO BOTTOM)	COLOR	HOLES TALL
Starter band	A	2

ROWS (TOP TO BOTTOM)	COLOR	HOLES TALL
Stripe 1	B	4
Stripe 2	A	4
Stripe 3	B	4
Stripe 4	A	4
Stripe 5	B	4
Stripe 6	A	4
Stripe 7	B	4
Total		30

Use this same color order on every panel so the stripes line up when you join the bag. The base panel is a single solid color (Color A), so it needs no pattern.

> **Edge color**
> For the final edge of the bag you will use Color A, the same color as the starter band. This gives a neat, framed look and hides the canvas.

Step by Step: Make Your Mini Clutch

Step 1: Cut the 6 canvas panels (Hour 0)

Lay a sheet of canvas on a table. Count the holes with your finger, not your eyes. Cut along the bars between holes, never through a hole. Leave one empty row of bars around every panel when you cut; this extra edge is what you will stitch over later.

1. **Front panel:** 42 holes wide x 30 holes tall.
2. **Back panel:** 42 holes wide x 30 holes tall.
3. **Two side panels:** each 12 holes wide x 30 holes tall.
4. **Base panel:** 42 holes wide x 12 holes tall.
5. **Flap (optional):** 42 holes wide x 12 holes tall. Skip this piece if you prefer an open clutch.

Label each piece with a tiny pencil mark in the corner (front, back, side, base, flap). Pencil can be erased later or hidden by the yarn.

> **Quick check**
>
> Hold the front and back together. They should match exactly. Then lay the side panels along the edge: they should be the same height. If one piece is off by a row or two, recut it now.

Step 2: Stitch the front panel (Hour 1)

Thread your needle with about 24 inches of yarn. Do not make a knot. Leave a 1-inch tail at the back and hold it down with your first few stitches.

Use continental stitch (also called tent stitch), as taught in the book. Work from the top left of the panel, one row at a time. Start with the 2-hole starter band in Color A, then follow the stripe table above.

- Each stitch covers one canvas intersection and goes diagonally.
- Every new row begins directly below the last one; do not skip a hole.
- Do not pull too tight. The yarn should lie flat and cover the canvas fully.
- When a strand gets short, weave the end under the stitches on the back for about an inch, then trim.

When you change colors for a new stripe, finish the old color by weaving it into the back. Start the new color the same way. This keeps the back flat and tidy.

Step 3: Stitch the back panel (Hour 2)

Repeat Step 2 on the second 42 × 30 piece. Use the same color order, the same direction, and the same tension. It gets easier and faster now because you already know the rhythm.

> **Tip for a clean look**
>
> Put your finished front beside the back as you work. Compare the stripes. They should start and end at exactly the same row.

Step 4: Stitch the sides, the base and the flap (Hour 3)

1. **Two side panels (12 × 30):** use the same stripe order as the front and back, so the stripes continue around the bag.
2. **Base panel (42 × 12):** stitch the whole piece in Color A. This is the quickest piece.
3. **Flap (optional, 42 × 12):** stitch it in Color A, or in the same stripe style for a more playful look.

Take a little break after this step. You are past the halfway mark, and every piece is finished.

Step 5: Assemble the bag (Hour 4)

Use Color A and a whipstitch. This is the simple over-the-edge stitch from the book's basics chapter.

1. Place the front and one side panel with their stitched faces up, edge to edge. Whipstitch along the joining edge from bottom to top.

2. Add the second side panel to the other end of the front the same way.
3. Add the back panel to the free edges of the two side panels, again from bottom to top. You now have a stitched tube.
4. Place the base panel at the bottom. Whipstitch all four sides of the base to the bottom edges of the tube. Go slowly around the corners and take two stitches in each corner hole for strength.
5. Whipstitch the flap to the top edge of the back panel, if you are using it.

Finish the top opening edges with one row of whipstitch in Color A, covering any bare canvas that shows. A full, even edge makes your bag look bought from a boutique.

> **No canvas showing**
>
> Look at the edges in good light. If you can see white or clear plastic, add one more whipstitch there. Never leave it for later.

Step 6: Attach the chain (Hour 5)

Cut your chain to about 20 to 24 inches, or leave it longer if you want a shoulder strap. Attach it with jump rings (closed with small pliers) or hook it onto a small loop of yarn sewn into the inside side seams of the bag.

- Place the attachment point on the inside of each side seam, close to the top edge.
- Pull gently on the chain. It should feel secure and not wobble.
- If you have the magnetic snap, glue or sew one half to the center of the flap and the other half to the front, matching the places.

Step 7: Add the felt lining (Hour 5)

The felt covers the plastic canvas and gives a soft, finished look inside. It also hides your yarn tails.

1. Cut one piece of felt the size of the inside of the front, one for the back, and one for the base. You can cut the sides as one long strip.
2. Add a few small dots of hot glue to the back of the felt, not too many, or it will look lumpy.
3. Press the felt into place and hold for 10 seconds.
4. Trim any felt edges that peek out above the top edge of the bag.

> **Glue gun reminder**
>
> Hot glue is hot enough to burn. Press the felt with a spoon, a piece of cardboard or a finger covered by a thick cloth, not a bare fingertip.

Is It Ready to Sell? The Final Checklist

Before you take a single photo, do a quality check. A bag that looks neat and feels sturdy sells faster and gets better reviews. Look at it in daylight and turn it over slowly in your hands.

READY-TO-SELL CHECKLIST

- [ ] The edges are clean, even and fully covered with yarn.
- [ ] No bare canvas is visible anywhere, including the corners and inside.
- [ ] The stripes line up around the bag, from front to side to back.
- [ ] There are no loose yarn tails or fuzz on the outside.
- [ ] The chain is attached firmly and does not wobble.
- [ ] The flap or the closing feels firm and holds shut.
- [ ] The felt lining is smooth and not coming loose.
- [ ] The bag keeps its shape when you gently squeeze it.
- [ ] Nothing sharp is poking out from the inside.
- [ ] You have written down the total cost of materials and your time.

If you can say yes to every line, congratulations. You have a finished bag that is ready to sell.

How to Photograph Your Bag with Window Light

You do not need a camera or a studio. A phone and a window are enough. Good photos can make the same bag look twice as valuable.

1. **Find soft light:** pick a window with bright light but no direct sun, ideally in the morning or the late afternoon. A cloudy day is perfect.
2. **Turn off the room lights:** mixed light makes the colors look odd. Use only the window.
3. **Pick a plain background:** a white sheet, a poster board or a clean wooden table. Remove everything else.

4. **Place the bag next to the window:** the light should hit the front from the side, at about a 45-degree angle. Put a white paper or card on the opposite side to bounce light back and soften the shadows.
5. **Clean your phone lens:** a quick wipe makes a big difference.
6. **Take the shots:** front, back, side, inside (to show the lining), a close-up of the stitches, and one with the bag in your hand or on your shoulder for scale.
7. **Edit lightly:** brighten the photo a touch and crop it. Do not add heavy filters. The colors should look like the real bag.

> **Be honest in your photos**
>
> Show the real size, color and finish. Buyers appreciate honesty, and honest photos mean fewer returns and happier customers.

What to Do Tomorrow

Today you made a bag. Tomorrow you put it in front of people. Keep it simple: pick one place where you already have friends or followers, such as a Facebook group, WhatsApp contacts, Instagram or a local Marketplace listing. Etsy is a great option later, once you have several bags.

Your first sales message in 3 lines

Copy this, change the words to sound like you, and send it with your photos:

> **Sample message**
>
> Hi! I just finished a handmade striped clutch, made stitch by stitch with a felt lining and a chain strap. It is about 6 × 4 inches, only one available, and I am offering it for [your price]. Would you like to see more photos?

For more ready-made messages, open Bonus 1 (Copy & Send Sales Scripts). For pricing ideas, use Bonus 4 (The $75 Pricing Formula).

A little math, as an example only

Say your supplies cost $7 and the bag took about 5 hours. If you sell it for $25, you would keep $18 after materials. That is just an example of arithmetic, not a promise. Your real results depend on your time, your market, your price and your effort.

Keep a simple note for each bag: the cost of supplies, the time it took, and the price you charged. Within a few bags you will know what works for you.

> **A friendly reminder**
>
> This guide is educational and shares general craft and selling ideas. It is not legal or tax advice. Check your local rules about selling handmade goods and reporting income.

Common Questions

My stripes look wavy. What happened?

Usually the tension changed. Pull each stitch with the same gentle pressure. A light steam over the finished panel (without touching the felt) can also relax the yarn.

I ran out of yarn in the middle of a row.

Finish the row with a new strand. Weave in both ends on the back. No one will see it.

I do not have a glue gun.

Use a strong craft glue or fabric glue applied in small dots. Let it dry fully before turning the bag.

Can I make it bigger?

Yes, but wait until your second bag. The Mini size is the fastest way to learn, and the book has many patterns for larger bags.

Next Step

Open the book to Chapter 1 and look at Pattern #001 once more. Then choose your next stripes or heart pattern, and make bag number two this week. Repeating a project you already know is the fastest way to become quick and confident.